Phase 0 · Production document

Art Bible

The visual rules for every model, texture, light, creature and page in the game, so that library assets and custom work look like one world.

Applies to	All five episodes · Episode 1 in detail
Version	1.0 · October 2026
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01 Visual Pillars

Pillar	What it means in practice
A 1930s photograph come to life	Warm sepia mid-tones, soft grain, gentle vignetting, slightly lifted blacks in daylight and deep blacks at night. Nothing looks digitally clean.
Warm flame against cold dark	Every night scene is built from two temperatures: amber light from flames and blue-grey from the moon or the dark. The player's lamp is always the warmest thing on screen.
Darkness is a material	Darkness is designed, not just absent light. Silhouettes must still read at the edge of the lamp; true black is reserved for places where something may be hiding.
Grounded and lived-in	Realistic proportions, worn surfaces, objects that have been used for decades. Exaggeration is reserved for the spirits.
Respect for the real	Khmer architecture, clothing and sacred objects are depicted accurately and with dignity (section 11).

02 Colour

2.1 Series base palette

Night ink	Old teak	Polished teak	Sepia mid	Paper / linen	Kerosene flame
#17120F	#3B2A1E	#8A5A3A	#C9A46A	#EFE4CF	#FF9A3C

2.2 Episode palettes

Episode 1 · The House of Mourning

Mahogany	Amber	Mourning white	Wet mud	Storm night	Brass
#5C3A26	#D98A3D	#F2EDE3	#6E6559	#2E3540	#C9A227

Episode 2 · The Whispering Pagoda

Moonlight	Moss stone	Deep navy	Cold silver	Lotus gold	Temple red
#8FA8D8	#5F6B5A	#1D2A44	#C7CCD4	#E3B65A	#9C3B2E

Episode 3 · The Drowned Village

Afternoon gold	Dark teal	Flood brown	Gunmetal	Clinic teal paint	Lamp amber
#E9C27A	#1F4D50	#5A4A33	#5D6670	#7FA8A1	#FFB15E

Episode 4 · The Rubber Plantation

Fog grey	Olive	Rust	Stucco yellow	Earth	Furnace
#9A9C94	#5B6328	#A04E24	#D8C27A	#4A3A2A	#FF7A2A

Episode 5 · The Sunken Sanctuary

Sandstone	Jungle	Rune gold	Night navy	Spirit amber	Dawn
#8B8273	#3F5A3A	#F0C24B	#18223A	#D9A05B	#FFD9A0

2.3 Colour rules

- **Saturation is earned.** Most surfaces stay below about 40% saturation. Strong colour is reserved for flame, blood, brass, sacred red and gold, and the daylight market.
- **Blood** is dark and brownish (`#5E1A14`), never bright red, and it looks like ink on paper.
- **Memories and flashbacks** shift to warm sepia with lower contrast so the player always knows they are in the past.

03 Lighting

Light	Colour	Rules
Player lamp (open)	`#FF9A3C` ~1900 K	The hero light: high-resolution soft shadows. Useful light 6–8 m; falls off fast beyond. Flicker: intensity ±12% with smooth noise at 6–10 Hz; stronger flicker when oil is low or Sora is cold.
Player lamp (shuttered)	Same	Leaks a thin line of light (0.5 m) through the shutter slits; the player can still see their hands.
Candles, oil lamps, incense	`#FFB15E`	Clustered point lights, radius 2–4 m, with emissive flame cards and bloom; up to 4 nearby flames may cast shadows in key moments. Flicker out of phase with each other.
Moonlight	`#8FA8D8`	Low intensity; one directional light; used for silhouettes, not for seeing detail.
Lightning	`#DFE8FF`	Very short (80–150 ms) bursts that briefly reveal the space; schedule them, never use them as a cheap jump scare more than once per area.
Daylight (Ep 3 market)	Warm afternoon	The only daylight scene in the night episodes. Bright, saturated, lively, to make the coming night darker by contrast.
Baked lighting	—	Static architecture uses lightmaps baked in Blender, layered with real-time SSAO, contact shadows and screen-space reflections on wet surfaces.

DARKNESS RULE

A player standing in the dark with the lamp off should see faint shapes within about 2 m after a few seconds (simulated eye adjustment). Pure, unreadable black is used only for doorways, the space under furniture and the backs of rooms, where the player must imagine what is there.

04 Post-Processing and Camera

Effect	Default (target)	Notes
Film grain	Intensity 8–12, animated	Toggle in settings. Stronger in memories.
Vignette	Weight 1.5, soft	Darkens further when Sora is afraid, wet or hurt.
Chromatic aberration	Small, edges only	Toggle in settings; spikes briefly during scares.
Bloom	Threshold high, low weight	Flames, runes, moonbeams only.
Ambient occlusion	SSAO, medium radius	Grounds props and deepens corners.
Reflections	Screen-space, wet surfaces only	Mud, puddles, floodwater, polished teak.
Volumetrics	Fog and light shafts	Lamp halo in rain and fog; moonbeams (Ep 2); dense fog (Ep 4).
Anti-aliasing	Temporal (TAA)	Keeps thin geometry (thread, floor gaps) stable.
Colour grading	One lookup table per episode	Built from the palettes in section 2.
Exposure	Slow auto-exposure, 2–3 s adaptation	Makes stepping out of the lamplight feel blind for a moment.
Field of view	75° default (60–95° in settings)	
Head-bob	Subtle; stronger when running	Toggle in settings.
Camera height	1.58 m standing · 0.95 m crouched · 0.45 m crawling	Sora is about 1.62 m tall.

05 Scale, Geometry and Modular Kits

5.1 Units and grid

- **1 Blender unit = 1 metre.** Z is up in Blender; the glTF exporter converts to Y-up.
- Modular pieces snap to a **0.5 m grid**; pivots at the bottom-left corner of each piece.
- Door openings 0.9 × 2.0 m (low, to fit traditional houses); ceiling 2.7 m; stair step 0.2 m rise, 0.25 m tread.

5.2 Stilt house kit (Episode 1)

Piece	Dimensions	Notes
Stilt post	0.25 m diameter, 2.5 m + floor	Slight taper; weathered base with mud stains.
Floor plank strip	0.20 m wide, 1 cm gaps, 3 m long	Gaps are real geometry so light and shadow pass through.
Wall panel	1.0 × 2.7 m, vertical boards	Variants: plain, window shutter, door, loose plank.
Roof section	Pitch 40–45°, tiled	Gable end variants with carved bargeboard.
Stairs	1.0 m wide, 13 steps	Front and rear.
Veranda railing	1.0 m sections, 0.9 m high	

5.3 Polygon budgets

Asset class	Triangles (LOD0)	LODs
Player items (lamp, matchbox, sketchbook, satchel)	20,000–50,000	None (always close)
First-person hands	25,000–40,000	None
Characters (Yay Mey, Vuthy)	60,000–100,000	3 LODs
Hero props (coffin, gramophone, chest)	15,000–40,000	2 LODs
Small props	500–8,000	Instanced
Modular architecture piece	500–6,000	Merged per area

Keep the whole visible scene within the 3-million-triangle budget from the Development Plan.

06 Materials and Textures

Rule	Detail
Workflow	PBR metal/roughness (glTF standard): base colour, normal, and a packed occlusion-roughness-metallic map.
Texel density	Environment 1,024 px/m · hero props 2,048 px/m · player items 4,096 px/m equivalent.
Maximum sizes	4096^2 for hero assets, player items and trim sheets · 2048^2 for props · 1024^2 for small props. All shipped as KTX2.
Trim sheets	One teak trim sheet (planks, beams, carved edges) and one plaster/stucco trim sheet cover most architecture.
Wear	Every surface shows age: worn edges, grime in corners, water marks at the base of walls and posts.
Wetness	A shader parameter darkens base colour and lowers roughness; used for rain, mud and flooded rooms.
Library assets	Always retexture or tint library assets to the episode palette and add wear before use.

07 Architecture References

Place	Key features to capture	Where to look
Battambang stilt house	Raised teak frame, gabled tiled roof, wide front stairs, open space beneath used for storage, carts and animals; shutters rather than glass.	Historic photos (EFEO, Gallica, ANOM); surviving old houses around Battambang
Funeral pavilion	Bamboo frame, white cloth, decorations, flags, coffin on a raised stand, portrait and offerings.	Interviews and photos from Cambodian families (with permission)
Village pagoda	Vihear with stacked roofs and naga finials, stupas of many sizes, kuti huts, library on stilts in a pond.	Battambang pagodas; ethnographic photo archives
Tonle Sap floating village	Houses on floats and stilts, boats as streets, colonial-era clinic in French-Khmer style.	Historic photos of the lake communities
Colonial estate	Yellow stucco, arched verandas, shutters, tiled roofs, industrial sheds of brick and iron.	Archive photos of 1920s–30s plantations
Phnom Kulen	Angkorian sandstone, naga balustrades, riverbed carvings, banyan roots through stone.	Published surveys and photography (keep the in-game site fictional)

Keep a reference folder per location with the source of every image. Reference images are for study only; never copy a photograph into a texture without a licence.

08 Characters and Costume

Character	Look	Notes
Sora (hands only)	Slim hands with ink stains on the right index and middle fingers; a thin silver bangle (her mother's); sleeves of a long-sleeved cotton blouse. Her full appearance is seen only in her own self-portrait in the sketchbook.	The ink stains show her art; the bangle links her to Kanha.
Yay Mey	Small, upright, white mourning clothes: chong kben and sash; short grey hair; betel-stained lips; prayer beads.	Confirm mourning customs for elderly women with the advisor (for example, head-shaving).
Vuthy	Late twenties; white or cream linen suit of a 1930s clerk, slightly too big; neat hair; a cheap wristwatch he keeps checking.	Looks out of place in the village; muddier each episode.
Uncle Sok	Gaunt, grey stubble, wrapped in white cloth in the coffin; in memories, a medic's white coat (1920) and worn civilian clothes (1931).	
Kanha	In the photograph and memories: warm, smiling, with Sora's eyes. As the spirit: long black hair, pale skin seen through water, never fully clear until the moment of release.	Handle with care (section 11).
Venerable Sophal	Elderly, saffron robes, clouded eyes.	Monks are always depicted respectfully.

09 Spirits and Creatures

Spirit	Design language	Rules
Neak Ta	Silhouette first: a towering shape of layered shadow, like smoke and stone. The **brass mask** is the only detailed element: hammered, ancient, slightly asymmetrical, with deep eye sockets that catch the lamp. In Episode 5: multiple arms, stone texture showing through the shadow.	Never fully lit before Episode 5. Never copy a real deity's iconography. Dignified, not grotesque: a judge.
Neak Ta shadow forms	The guardian's lesser forms: tall, stooped, wet shadows in the house (Ep 1) and the manor (Ep 4); weathered statues in the Earth trial (Ep 5). They share the mask's brass glint in the eyes so players recognise one spirit.	Mostly shown through shadows and sound.
Pich (Mrenh Kongveal)	Never fully seen: a small silhouette at the edge of the light, a child's wet handprint on a dry board, a little wooden toy that rolls. Warm-toned, never pale or distorted.	Gentle; never used for a scare.
Apsara dance (Ep 5)	Carved dancers that move gracefully for a few seconds, with stone texture and soft golden light.	Gestures based on real classical dance, checked with a dancer or the advisor. Beautiful, never grotesque.
Pret	Based on traditional depictions: 3–4 m tall, extremely thin limbs, needle-thin neck, tiny mouth, swollen belly, hollow glowing eyes.	Pitiful as well as frightening; they are suffering.
Chhlong Tonle (Kanha)	A shape made of water and long hair; a face that resolves only near the end of Episode 3.	Never sexualised or gory.
Khmaoch Prey	Tall, slender, disfigured; elongated limbs that look like rubber trees in the fog until they move.	Mostly heard, rarely seen.

10 The Sketchbook and Interface Art

Paper	Cream (`#EFE4CF`) with faint texture, foxing at the edges, slight wrinkling after Episode 3 (it got wet).
Drawing style	Sora's own: confident fountain-pen line, ink wash shading, quick gesture sketches of people and places, neat architectural plans for maps.
Handwriting	English notes in a hand-lettered style; Khmer notes in Sora's handwriting. Chosen in S5: **Patrick Hand** (English) and **Freehand** (Khmer), both SIL Open Font Licence, credited in the game. For menus and settings, use **Ubuntu** (English) and **Preah Vihear** (Khmer), matching the documents.
Blood on the map	Dark brown-red ink that spreads with a slow, organic bleed animation.
Night count	Seven hand-drawn circles across the top of the map page, filled with ink wash one by one.
Kanha's drawings	Softer pencil style; Sora's style clearly descends from it.
Title logo	English title in Ubuntu Bold; Khmer title in a decorative Khmer display face (for example, Moul) to be chosen with the advisor.

11 Sensitivity Rules

ALWAYS

- Show Buddha images, monks, stupas and altars with respect: well lit, intact, never as monsters or jump scares.
- Base clothing, architecture and ritual objects on research and advisor review.
- Show the plantation labourers as people with names and dignity.
- Let the spirits be frightening *and* sympathetic.
- Show classical and village dance as beauty, joy and offering, never as ghosts or monsters.

NEVER

- Damage, desecrate or mock sacred images or objects.
- Copy the iconography of a specific real deity or a real Neak Ta shrine.
- Use gore for shock; blood stays small and symbolic.
- Sexualise any character, living or dead.

12 Asset Approval Checklist

✓	Before an asset goes into the game
□	Correct real-world scale; snaps to the 0.5 m grid if modular; pivot placed correctly
□	Within its triangle budget; LODs where required
□	Textures at the right texel density and maximum size; exported as KTX2
□	Colours within the episode palette; wear and age added
□	Reads clearly at the edge of the lamplight and in silhouette
□	Named per the Technical Design Document; licence recorded in the asset tracker
□	Culturally specific assets reviewed against references (and by the advisor where needed)